

At the last ever spotlight, we watched a really interesting video. This video completely changed how I think about trash in New York City. It starts with the contrast between the famous skyline and the forty four million pounds of trash the city produces every day, and points out that only about a fifth of it is recycled. By comparing New York with cities that recycle much more, the video makes clear that low recycling is a choice, not fate.

I liked how it treated the city as a data problem. The presenters used open records and their own observations to map recycling rates across neighborhoods, then tested how income, infrastructure, and time relate to those patterns. Their simple models show that, without major policy changes, recycling rates are unlikely to improve much. That conclusion felt blunt but honest.

The example of curbside composting in Queens showed that policy can work. Once food scraps collection became mandatory, organic waste diversion climbed, even through the disruption of Covid. The discussion of contamination, like how a greasy pizza box or unrinsed container can ruin a whole bin, made my own habits feel more important than I had realized.

The black hole analogy at the end tied it together for me. Trash does not disappear when we toss it out, it keeps affecting climate, pollution, and health. The video left me feeling that individual behavior matters, but also that citizens armed with data can push their cities toward smarter waste policies.